

Open Card Game Rules Reference

Original write-ups of traditional and popular card games

6 games for 1 to 8 players, playable with the decks you already own.

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SOLITAIRE (1 PLAYER)

FreeCell

Also known as	Free Cell, FreeCell Solitaire
Players	1 player
Deck	1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed
Time	10-30 minutes
Difficulty	Easy
Category	Solitaire (1 player)

Setup

Take one 52-card deck without jokers, shuffle it, and deal the whole pack face up into eight tableau columns: seven cards each to the first four columns and six each to the last four. Spread each column so that every card in it stays readable, with the last card of the column fully exposed.

Above or beside the tableau, set out four free cells on one side and four foundation spaces on the other. All eight start empty.

That is the entire layout. There is no stock, no waste and no redeal, and nothing is dealt face down. From the first move to the last you are working with complete information, which is what separates FreeCell from Klondike and Spider. No new card can turn up, so a deal is a puzzle that is already either solvable or not before you touch it.

Play

The foundations are built up in suit from the ace to the king, one foundation per suit. The tableau columns are built down in alternating colours, so a black jack accepts a red 10 and that red 10 accepts a black 9.

Strictly speaking exactly one card moves at a time, and it has to be either the exposed card at the end of a column or a card sitting in a free cell. You can send it to:

- a foundation, if it is the next rank up in that suit;
- a tableau column whose end card is one rank higher and the opposite colour;
- an empty free cell, which holds exactly one card and imposes no other condition;
- an empty column, which accepts any single card at all. Unlike Klondike, empty columns are not reserved for kings, and this is the most powerful resource in the game.

A card parked in a free cell is fully available and can be played out again to a column or a foundation whenever it fits. The only cost of using a cell is that it is no longer free for manoeuvring.

Almost every version lets you drag a whole run at once, which is the supermove, also called a power move. It is not a separate rule. It is shorthand for a run of ordinary single-card moves that the software performs for you: the upper cards of the run get shuffled into free cells and empty columns, the bottom card is moved, and the run is rebuilt on top of it. The number of

cards you can shift this way is therefore capped by the workspace you have:

maximum cards = $(1 + \text{empty free cells}) \times 2^{\text{(empty columns)}}$

With two cells open and no empty columns you can move three cards. With all four cells open and one empty column you can move ten. There is one catch: if the destination is itself an empty column, that column cannot double as workspace, so leave it out of the exponent. Moving into your only empty column with all four cells free gets you five cards, not ten.

The run you are moving must already be a proper descending, alternating-colour sequence. A stack that merely sits together is not movable as a block, and if you do not have the storage for the whole run you have to break it up by hand.

Taking a card back off a foundation into the tableau is allowed in most implementations and is occasionally the move that saves a deal, but some versions lock a foundation once a card is played there, so check before you count on it.

The deal ends when all four foundations reach their kings, or when you are stuck: every free cell occupied, no empty column, and no exposed card that fits anywhere.

Goal & scoring

You win by moving all 52 cards onto the foundations, each suit in order from ace up to king. FreeCell keeps no points in its traditional form. A deal is won or lost, and players who want a finer measure compare move counts or elapsed time on the same numbered deal rather than tallying a score.

The interesting number in FreeCell is how often a deal can be won at all. Because every card is visible and four cells is a generous allowance, nearly every deal has a solution: solvers put it at roughly 99.999 percent of random deals. Microsoft's original set of 32,000 numbered deals contains exactly one that has been proven impossible, deal 11,982, and establishing that took a volunteer effort running through the mid-1990s. When the same generator was extended to a million deals, only eight unwinnable ones turned up in total: 11,982, 146,692, 186,216, 455,889, 495,505, 512,118, 517,776 and 781,948.

Losing a FreeCell deal is therefore almost always your mistake rather than the shuffle's, which is both the appeal and the cruelty of the game. Solvable does not mean easy, though. Deals 617 and 1,941 from the original set are notorious, and 1,941 is widely nominated as the hardest solvable deal among the 32,000. Working through the numbered deals in order is a long-running informal challenge.

Variants

Baker's Game — The game FreeCell was derived from. Identical layout and identical four free cells, but the tableau builds down in suit instead of alternating colours. Removing colour-based landing spots roughly halves the places any card can go, and winnability drops from near-certainty to somewhere around three quarters of deals, so a lost game here is much less likely to be your fault.

Eight Off — Eight free cells rather than four. Deal 48 cards into eight columns of six, then place the remaining four cards one each into four of the eight cells, leaving four cells open.

The tableau builds down in suit, and only a king may be moved into an empty column. The extra cells are compensation for both of those tighter restrictions.

Seahaven Towers — Fifty cards go into ten columns of five, and the last two cards are placed into two of the four free cells, leaving two open. The tableau builds down in suit and only kings may fill an empty column. With ten short columns, two occupied cells and no colour alternation, it plays much more tightly than FreeCell and rewards planning several moves ahead.

ForeCell — Deal four cards face up into the four free cells first, then 48 cards into eight columns of six. You start with every cell full, so your first job is emptying them. The tableau builds down in alternating colours as in FreeCell, but only a king may be moved into an empty column, which removes the escape hatch that makes standard FreeCell so forgiving.

Rules verified against: Wikipedia, Solitaire Laboratory, Solitaire Central, BVS Solitaire, PlayFreeCellOnline, Freecell Solver documentation (Shlomi Fish). Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Golf

Also known as Golf Solitaire, Golf Patience, One Foundation

Players 1 player

Deck 1 standard deck (52 cards)

Time 5-15 minutes

Difficulty Simple

Category Solitaire (1 player)

Setup

Shuffle a full 52-card deck. Deal 35 cards face up into seven columns of five. Overlap the cards in each column so every rank stays readable, with the last card dealt to a column sitting at the exposed end. All 35 are visible from the start, so nothing is hidden. The 17 cards left over become the stock, kept face down in a single pile. Turn the top stock card face up beside it to start the waste pile, which is the one pile you will build on for the rest of the deal. That leaves 16 cards in the stock. Leave room for the waste to grow, since in a good deal nearly the whole pack ends up there. There are no foundations by suit and no reserve; the seven columns, the stock, and the waste are the entire layout.

Play

Only the exposed card at the open end of each column is in play. The rest are locked until the cards covering them are gone.

On your turn you may move any one exposed column card onto the waste pile, provided its rank is exactly one higher or one lower than the current top card of the waste. Suits and colours are ignored entirely. If the waste shows a 9, you may play any 8 or any 10. Moving a card exposes the one behind it in that column, which may then be playable in turn, so a single well-placed card can start a long chain.

Ranks do not wrap in the standard game. Aces are low and kings are high: only a 2 plays onto an ace, and only a queen plays onto a king. Playing an ace on a king, or a king on an ace, is illegal. This is the single rule that ends most deals, and the most commonly relaxed one.

You may keep making legal moves for as long as you like; you are never forced to draw. Cards never move between columns, never move back off the waste, and never go onto the stock. Once a column is emptied the gap stays empty for the rest of the deal, and nothing may be placed there.

When you are stuck, or simply choose to, turn the next card of the stock face up onto the waste. That card becomes the new build card regardless of what it covers, so a draw can reset the sequence to any rank. Drawing is the only way to change the top of the waste other than playing a column card.

The deal ends when the stock is empty and no exposed column card can legally be played onto the waste. There is no redeal and no shuffling of the waste back into the stock. If you have cleared all 35 column cards you have holed out; otherwise the deal is over with cards still on

the table.

A separate multiplayer game is also called Golf. That one is usually played as Six-Card Golf, where each player manages a private face-down grid, swapping and discarding to reach the lowest total over nine deals. The two games share only the golf scoring metaphor and are otherwise unrelated; the rules here are for the single-player patience.

Goal & scoring

The object of a single deal is to clear all 35 cards out of the seven columns and onto the waste. Cards left in the stock do not matter.

Score as in golf: count one stroke for every card still stranded in the columns when the deal ends. Clearing the tableau scores zero for the hole, and a common house rule lets you go under par by subtracting one for each card still face down in the stock when you hole out.

A full round is nine deals, one per hole, with the strokes added up. Under strict no-wraparound rules most deals cannot be cleared, so a nine-hole total in the mid-thirties is a solid round and anything at or below par of about 45 is respectable. Two rounds of nine make an eighteen-hole match.

Variants

Putt Putt (wraparound) — Ranks wrap, so a king may be played on an ace and an ace on a king, making the sequence a continuous loop. This removes the dead ends that spoil most strict deals and lifts the win rate dramatically, which is why nearly every computer version offers it as an easy mode.

Relaxed stock — Allow one redeal: gather the waste after the stock runs out, turn it over without shuffling, and use it as a fresh stock. Some house rules instead let you undo the last move or deal a shorter tableau of six columns of five, leaving 22 cards in the stock. All of these trade difficulty for a better chance of holing out.

Black Hole — David Parlett's rework. Deal 17 fans of three cards around the ace of spades, which sits alone in the centre as the only foundation. Build up or down on it with wraparound, taking the exposed card of any fan, and there is no stock at all. Everything is visible from the start, so it plays as a puzzle rather than a gamble, and the great majority of deals are solvable.

All in a Row — Also by Parlett. The whole deck is dealt into 13 overlapping fans of four cards in a single row, with no stock and no starting foundation card. The first card you take becomes the base of the waste and you build up or down with wraparound from there, aiming to absorb all 52 cards.

Double Golf — Two shuffled decks are used, dealt into a wider tableau such as eight columns of eight, with the remainder as stock. Play is otherwise identical. Duplicated ranks give more branching options, but the larger layout means a single dead run can still leave a heavy score.

Rules verified against: [Wikipedia](#), [Solitaire Central Rulebook](#), [Solitaire Laboratory](#), [Wikibooks Solitaire card games](#), [Parlett Games](#), [Bicycle Cards](#). Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Klondike

Also known as Solitaire, Patience, Klondike Solitaire, Canfield

Players 1 player

Deck 1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed

Time 5-20 minutes

Difficulty Easy

Category Solitaire (1 player)

Setup

Use a single 52-card deck with the jokers removed. Shuffle, then build seven tableau piles from left to right: one card in the first pile, two in the second, on up to seven in the seventh, for 28 cards in total. The tidy way to deal it is one card to each pile in a left-to-right sweep, skipping any pile that already holds its full count. Turn the exposed card of every pile face up and leave everything under it face down.

Above the tableau, reserve four spaces for the foundations. They start empty. The 24 cards you did not deal go face down in a single packet as the stock, with an empty space beside it for the waste. There is no dealer to choose and no opponent, so play begins the moment the layout is built.

Play

There are two places to build. The four foundations go up in suit starting from the ace: move an ace up as soon as one is exposed, then the 2 of that suit, and so on through the king. The seven tableau piles go down in alternating colours, so a red 9 accepts a black 8, and that black 8 accepts a red 7.

Playable cards are the exposed card at the outer end of each tableau pile and the top card of the waste. You may move one of those to a foundation, or to a tableau pile whose exposed card is one rank higher and the opposite colour. You may also lift a properly ordered run of face-up tableau cards and move it as a unit onto a card that continues the sequence. Most rule sets let you take just the lower portion of a run; stricter ones make you move the whole face-up group or nothing.

Any time a move leaves a face-down card at the end of a tableau pile, turn it up immediately.

Empty columns carry the one real restriction: only a king, or a run headed by a king, may be moved into a column you have cleared. Nothing else may go there, so emptying a column with no king in sight usually wastes the space.

When you run out of tableau moves, work the stock. Turn cards face up onto the waste and play from there. Only the top card of the waste is ever playable, and it leaves one card at a time. How many cards you turn per go is the setting that defines the two common versions.

Draw one: turn a single card at a time. Every card in the stock reaches the top of the waste on every pass, so nothing stays out of reach and the game is far more forgiving.

Draw three: turn three at once, overlapped so you can read all three but only the outermost is playable. The two behind it become available only after the card in front of them is played. Because the stock is consumed in blocks of three, roughly two thirds of it is unreachable at any given moment, and every card you take shifts which cards surface on the next pass. This is the older and harder default.

When the stock runs out, turn the waste over without shuffling to form a new stock. That is a redeal, and its limit is the other point players argue about. Casual play generally allows unlimited redeals in both draw modes. Scored and timed versions cap it: three passes through the stock, meaning two redeals, is the usual draw-three convention, while draw one and Vegas scoring are often played with a single pass and no redeal at all. Settle the limit before you deal.

Taking the top card back off a foundation into the tableau is permitted in most rule sets and is sometimes the only way to free a card you need, though scored versions charge you for it and a few rule sets forbid it outright.

The deal ends when all four foundations are complete, or when you are stuck: nothing playable from any tableau pile, nothing playable off the waste, and no redeal left.

Goal & scoring

You win by getting all 52 cards onto the foundations, each suit built ace through king. Most people simply play win or lose and keep no score.

Standard scoring, the system most software uses, awards 5 points for moving a card from the waste to the tableau, 10 for moving a card to a foundation, and 5 for turning up a face-down tableau card. Pulling a card back from a foundation costs 15. Recycling the stock costs points once you are past the first pass, commonly 20 in draw three and a steeper charge in draw one, where an extra pass is worth much more. Timed play adds a bonus that grows the faster you finish.

Vegas scoring treats the deal as a wager. You buy the deck for 52 units, one per card, and collect 5 units for every card you land on a foundation, so eleven cards puts you 3 ahead and break-even is closer than it looks. You normally get one pass through the stock, and many players carry a running bankroll from deal to deal.

Klondike is not always winnable, which matters more than beginners expect. Exhaustive computer analysis of draw-three Klondike with every face-down card revealed in advance puts the ceiling at about 82 percent of deals, so roughly one deal in six cannot be won by anyone regardless of skill. Draw one is more winnable than that. Playing blind, as you actually do, real results are much lower: large samples of players come in near a third of games at draw one and around one game in ten at draw three.

Variants

Vegas Klondike — Klondike played as a bet. You pay 52 units for the deck, one per card, and earn 5 units for each card you get onto a foundation, so eleven cards is break-even plus a little. Only one pass through the stock is allowed, with no redeal, which makes the draw-three version brutal. Many players keep a cumulative bankroll across a session instead

of settling each deal separately.

Thoughtful Klondike — Identical to ordinary Klondike except that the identity of every face-down card is known from the start. It is mostly a research construct: because the only difference is information, any deal solvable in Thoughtful Klondike is solvable in Klondike too, so solving it gives an upper bound on how often the real game can be won. This is where the roughly 82 percent figure for draw three comes from.

Double Klondike — Two decks, 104 cards, nine tableau piles dealt one through nine, and eight foundations, two per suit. Building rules are unchanged: foundations up in suit from the ace, tableau down in alternating colours, kings only into empty columns. The extra piles make it noticeably easier to win than single-deck Klondike. The name is also used for a two-player race in which each player has their own tableau but both feed a shared set of foundations.

Whitehead — The same 28-card, seven-pile layout as Klondike, but everything is dealt face up so there is nothing hidden. The tableau builds down in matching colour rather than alternating colour, red on red and black on black. Only runs that are entirely of one suit may be moved as a block, and an empty column will take any card or run, not just a king.

Rules verified against: [Wikipedia](#), [Solitaire Laboratory](#), [GameRules.com](#), [Solitaired](#), [Solitaire.com](#), [BVS Solitaire](#), [Solvitaire winnability study \(Blake and Gent\)](#). Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Pyramid

Also known as Pyramid Solitaire, Solitaire Thirteen, Pile of Twenty-Eight

Players 1 player

Deck 1 standard deck (52 cards)

Time 5-15 minutes

Difficulty Easy

Category Solitaire (1 player)

Setup

Shuffle a full 52-card deck and build the pyramid face up in seven rows. Lay one card at the top, then two below it, then three, and so on down to a bottom row of seven, for 28 cards in all. Offset each row so that every card rests on and partly covers the two cards above it, and so that each card in turn is partly covered by the two below it. Only the seven cards of the bottom row start out completely uncovered.

The remaining 24 cards form the stock, squared up face down to one side. Leave space next to it for a waste pile and space somewhere clear for discards. Ranks count as numbers throughout: ace is 1, jack is 11, queen is 12, king is 13, and every other card is its face value. Suit and colour never matter.

Play

A card is available only when nothing overlaps it. In the pyramid that means both cards below it have already been removed. The bottom row is available from the start; each removal frees the cards above once their other supporter also goes.

Remove available cards in pairs that add to exactly 13. The pairings are ace with queen, 2 with jack, 3 with 10, 4 with 9, 5 with 8, and 6 with 7. Kings are worth 13 on their own, so any available king is removed by itself at any time. Removed cards are set aside for good and never come back into play.

Both cards of a pair must be available at the moment you take them, but they need not be in the same place. You may pair two uncovered pyramid cards, or one pyramid card with the top card of the waste. Two pyramid cards that sit side by side in the same row can be paired normally, since neither covers the other. What you cannot do is use a card that is still covered, however visible its rank is.

When you want a new card, turn the top card of the stock face up onto the waste. Only the top of the waste is live; the cards under it are buried until it is played. Play the turned card immediately if you can, or leave it and turn another. The card you just turned may be paired with the previous top of the waste, so two consecutive stock cards summing to 13 clear each other.

Draw at your own pace, and take any legal removal at any time. There is no obligation to draw when useful pairings remain on the table, and holding a convenient card on top of the waste while you work through the pyramid is a normal tactic.

In the standard game you get one pass through the stock and no redeal. The deal ends when the stock is exhausted and no further pair can be removed. Since a card buried in the waste is gone for the rest of the deal under those rules, the order in which you spend stock cards matters more than anything else you do.

Goal & scoring

You win by dismantling the whole pyramid: all 28 cards removed. Cards left in the stock or waste are ignored, so clearing the last pyramid card wins immediately even with a stack of unused cards beside you.

The traditional game keeps no score beyond won or lost. Under the strict single-pass rules a clear is genuinely uncommon, and a great many deals are unwinnable no matter how well you play, so judging yourself on wins per session is fairer than judging a single deal.

If you want a score, the usual convention is a penalty of one point per card left in the pyramid, tallied over several deals with the lowest total best. Computer versions often add time bonuses and streak bonuses on top, which is a house scoring layer rather than part of the game.

Variants

Three passes — After the stock runs out, turn the waste over without shuffling to make a new stock and go again. Two redeals, for three passes in total, is the most common relaxed setting and the one most computer versions default to. It rescues cards buried early in the first pass and raises the win rate substantially.

Draw three — Turn stock cards three at a time instead of one, with only the top of each triple available, and allow unlimited redeals to compensate. Sold as King Tut or Tut's Tomb in various solitaire collections. Buried cards become reachable eventually, but you have far less control over which card is showing at any given moment.

Giza — An open variant by Michael Keller. The pyramid is dealt as usual, but the 24 leftover cards go face up into eight piles of three instead of a face-down stock, with the top card of each pile available. Nothing is hidden and there is no drawing, so the deal is a pure planning puzzle that you either solve or do not.

Apophis — Deal the standard 28-card pyramid, then run the stock into three separate waste piles instead of one, choosing which pile each turned card goes on. The top card of all three piles is available at once, which gives you three live cards to work with and much better control over what you keep in reach.

Clear everything — A harder scoring condition rather than a different layout: you must remove all 52 cards, stock and waste included, not just the pyramid. Very few deals can be beaten this way, so it is best treated as an occasional challenge rather than the default.

Rules verified against: Wikipedia, Solitaire Central Rulebook, Wikibooks Solitaire card games, BVS Solitaire, Bicycle Cards, PlayingCardDecks. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

Spider

Also known as	Spider Solitaire, Spider Patience
Players	1 player
Deck	2 standard decks (104 cards); the easier settings replace the pack with repeated copies of one or two suits
Time	20-45 minutes
Difficulty	Easy
Category	Solitaire (1 player)

Setup

Spider is played with 104 cards, the equivalent of two standard decks. Which suits those cards come from is the difficulty setting. The four-suit game uses two full decks, two of each suit. The two-suit game uses four copies each of two suits, usually spades and hearts. The one-suit game uses eight copies of a single suit. With real cards you are effectively playing four-suit unless you go to the trouble of assembling a stripped pack, which is why the easier settings are mainly a computer thing.

Shuffle all 104 cards together and deal 54 of them into ten tableau columns: six cards each to the first four columns and five cards each to the remaining six. Deal them face down, then turn the exposed card of each column face up. The 50 cards left over become the stock, set aside face down. It will feed the tableau in five deals of ten.

There are no foundation piles to build on. Just leave a clear area beside the tableau for completed sequences, which come off the table intact. You will need room for eight of them.

Play

Everything happens in the tableau. Build columns downward by rank, and by rank alone: any 9 may be placed on any 10 whatever the suits. Aces are low and kings are high, so nothing can ever be placed on an ace, and a king can never be placed on another card.

Suit matters for moving, not for placing. You may always move the single exposed card at the end of a column. You may move several cards as a block only if they run in descending order and are all of the same suit. The 8, 7 and 6 of clubs travel together; a stack of club 8, heart 7, club 6 is a perfectly legal arrangement on the table but has to be taken apart one card at a time. That single restriction is what makes the multi-suit games hard, and it is the rule newcomers most often get wrong.

When a move uncovers a face-down card at the end of a column, turn it face up at once.

An empty column will accept any card, or any block you are allowed to move. Nothing is reserved for kings. Putting a king there is usually the strongest use of the space, though, since a column headed by a low card can only ever take a few more cards on top.

When you have no move worth making, deal from the stock: one card face up onto the end of every one of the ten columns, all at once. You may do this five times, which exactly exhausts the 50-card stock. There is one hard condition attached. Every column must contain at least

one card before you deal. If any column is empty you cannot deal, and you have to fill it first, even with a single junk card. Players regularly lose games by clearing a column and then discovering they have locked themselves out of the stock, so plan the deal before you empty anything. Note also that a deal drops a card onto every column whether it helps or not, so it will usually bury runs you were part way through assembling.

Whenever a full descending same-suit sequence from king down to ace sits at the end of a column, it is removed from the table and set aside. That sequence is finished and can never be touched again. Removing it exposes whatever was underneath, which is very often the real reason you built it.

The game ends when you have removed all eight sequences, or when the stock is empty and no remaining move gets you any closer.

Goal & scoring

You win by assembling and removing all eight complete king-to-ace sequences, each one entirely in a single suit, which clears every card off the table. Anything short of eight is a loss; there is no partial credit in casual play.

The scoring system carried by most software starts you at 500 points and takes off 1 point for every move you make, counting deals from the stock and counting undos. Each completed sequence you remove adds 100. A perfect game is therefore bounded above by 1,300, and real scores land well below that, since even efficient play burns hundreds of moves.

Not every deal can be won, and the suit setting changes the odds enormously. One-suit Spider is winnable nearly every time with careful play, with competent players reporting rates around 90 percent and higher. Two-suit is a real puzzle, with skilled play landing somewhere in the 30 to 40 percent range. Four-suit is the serious version: strong players usually win well under 20 percent of deals, and casual averages sit in the single digits. Unlike FreeCell, Spider has no authoritative exhaustive solvability study, so these numbers come from large samples of actual play rather than from solvers, and you should treat them as ballpark figures.

Variants

Spiderette — One deck, Klondike-shaped. Deal 28 cards into seven columns of one through seven, exposed card face up, and keep the other 24 as stock. Building, group movement and sequence removal follow Spider exactly, but you only need four king-to-ace suit sequences. The stock is dealt seven at a time, one card onto each column, and the last deal is short: three cards, going to the leftmost columns.

Will o' the Wisp — A faster one-deck Spider. Deal seven columns of three cards each, 21 in total, with only the exposed card of each column face up. The remaining 31 cards feed the tableau seven at a time. Everything else matches Spider, and four suit sequences win it. The shallow columns mean far less is hidden at the start, which makes it markedly kinder than Spiderette.

Black Widow — Spider with the group-move restriction dropped. Same two decks, same ten columns of six, six, five, and same five deals of ten from the stock, but any descending run may be picked up and moved as a block regardless of suit. Sequences still have to be all one

suit to be removed, so the goal is unchanged. Removing the hardest rule in Spider makes this the easiest game in the family.

Simple Simon — One deck, no stock, nothing hidden. All 52 cards go face up into ten columns of eight, eight, eight, seven, six, five, four, three, two and one. Build down by rank ignoring suit, move blocks only when they are same-suit descending runs, and put any card into an empty column. Remove the four king-to-ace suit sequences to win. With no stock and full information it is a pure puzzle rather than a game of chance.

Rules verified against: Wikipedia, Semicolon Solitaire Rules, Solitaired, BVS Solitaire, SuitedGames, TrySolitaire, Solitaire Bliss. Original text; not reproduced from those sources.

MATCHING & COLLECTING

Old Maid

Also known as Scabby Queen, Black Peter, Schwarzer Peter, Old Bachelor

Players 2-8 players (best with 4)

Deck 1 standard deck with one queen removed (51 cards)

Time 10-20 minutes

Difficulty Simple

Category Matching & collecting

Setup

Take a standard 52-card deck and pull out one queen, setting it aside face down where nobody can see which one it was. That leaves 51 cards: twelve ranks still complete at four cards each, and queens reduced to three. Everything can be matched into 25 pairs except one queen, which has nothing to go with. That leftover queen is the old maid.

Choose a dealer any way you like; cutting for high card works, and the deal passes to the left between games. Shuffle and deal the entire pack out one card at a time, going clockwise. It will not come out even. Some players end up with one card more than others, and that is fine and does not affect play.

Everyone picks up their hand and looks at it privately. Before the first turn, each player lays down every pair they were dealt, face up in front of them, and takes no further interest in those cards. A pair is two cards of the same rank; suit and colour are irrelevant. If you hold three of a kind, you may only discard two of them and must keep the third. If you hold all four of a rank, put down two pairs.

Play

Play moves clockwise. The dealer goes first, though many families instead start with the player to the dealer's left; agree before you begin, since it changes nothing but who is exposed first.

On your turn you hold your hand out to the player on your left, spread face down like a fan so the backs are toward them and no faces show. That player takes one card of their choice, blind, and adds it to their hand. If the card they drew makes a pair with something they already hold, they lay that pair down face up at once. If it does not, they simply keep it.

The player who just drew then becomes the one who offers, fanning their own hand face down to the player on their left, and so on around the table. Cards therefore move steadily around the circle, each player always drawing from the neighbour on their right and always offering to the neighbour on their left.

Shuffling your hand before you offer it is the whole skill of the game. Keeping the old maid in one spot, glancing at it, or holding it slightly proud will get it read instantly, especially by children, who are usually better at spotting a tell than adults expect.

When a player's hand becomes empty, whether by laying down a pair or by having their last card drawn away, that player is out and safe. Skip them from then on. Offering and drawing simply pass to the next player who still holds cards, closing the circle up as it shrinks.

The hand ends when every card that can be paired has been paired. At that point exactly one card is left in the game, held by exactly one player: the odd queen. There is no scoring round and no way to unload it once you are the last player holding cards, so the ending is always the same shape.

Goal & scoring

Your aim is to get rid of every card in your hand and, above all, not to be the one holding the unmatched queen at the end.

There is no point scoring. Everyone who empties their hand wins equally, and the single player left with the old maid loses that hand. Position or order of going out does not matter; being out first carries no extra credit.

Because the loser is decided entirely by blind draws and by how well people disguise their hands, results swing wildly from deal to deal. Groups that want a longer session usually play a fixed number of hands and count how many times each person was stuck as the old maid, with the lowest count winning overall. Some play instead until one player has been the old maid three times and is out.

Variants

Dedicated Old Maid deck — Purpose-made children's decks replace the standard pack with illustrated character pairs plus one unpaired Old Maid card. Play is identical, but the matching is by picture rather than rank, which makes it far easier for very young players who cannot yet read card ranks reliably.

Joker as the odd card — Instead of removing a queen, leave the deck complete at 52 and add a single joker, giving 53 cards. All four queens stay in and can be paired; the joker is the card nobody wants. This is how the game is usually played in Japan, where it is known as *babanuki*, and it saves you from fishing a card out of the pack.

Scabby Queen — A British version in which three queens are removed so that the queen of spades is the doomed card, and the loser takes a forfeit. Traditionally the loser cuts cards from the pack and is rapped across the knuckles with the deck a number of times set by the card drawn. Most groups now drop the physical penalty and keep only the named target card.

Black Peter — The continental European form, called *Schwarzer Peter* in Germany and *Svarte Petter* or *Svarteper* in Scandinavia. A jack, usually the jack of spades, is the unpairable card rather than a queen, and the loser is often marked with a smudge of soot or a drawn-on moustache. Many countries sell dedicated Black Peter decks in the same spirit as illustrated Old Maid packs.

Any odd card — Remove a card at random, face down, without anyone seeing which one it was, so nobody knows what the unpairable card is until the hand is nearly over. This kills the strategy of tracking one known queen and stops experienced players from reading the table

so easily. A Philippine version, ungguy-ungguyan, is played this way.

Rules verified against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Bicycle Cards, Gambiter, Card Game Wiki, Ducksters.
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